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HST 243: Soviet History Through Film

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Film Review

Released as a gift to celebrate Stalin's 70th birthday, *The Fall of Berlin* was bound to become a major film of its era. Ultimately, the movie achieved this milestone by depicting the Soviet experience of the Second World War. Being a notable example of late Stalinist cinematography, *The Fall of Berlin* reflected key attributes of the period, including the cult of victory, unofficial discrimination of non-Russian ethnicities, and Cold War propaganda.

The selected movie articulated one of the most significant objectives of late Stalinism, the creation of the victory cult. At this point, the cult of great victory was a socio-ideological phenomenon, which framed Soviet participation in the war as the ultimate triumph, retrospectively confirming the vitality and legitimacy of the Stalinist regime¹. Under this concept, industrialization and collectivization were presented as indispensable prerequisites for military success, thereby justifying sacrifices and struggles associated with these policies. Therefore, the strategic importance of the victory cult lay in the positive connotation it carried, which positioned Stalinism as the "extreme of absolute good" in contrast to the "absolute universal evil" of fascism². Chiaureli's film effectively demonstrated the attribution of victory to pre-war state initiatives in the opening scene of Alyosha's successes in the factory. As shown in Figure 1, industrial labor was depicted in the movie as an act of heroism, which, with the development of the plot, gradually transitioned into military service.

¹ Dobrenko, Evgeny. "Victory over the Revolution: A Transformed War." In *Late Stalinism: The Aesthetics of Politics*. Trans. by Jesse M. Savage, (Connecticut: Yale University Press, 2020), 37.

² Dobrenko, Victory over the Revolution, 36.



Figure 1. Alyosha in the factory from *The Fall of Berlin. Part 1*

The very transformation of Alyosha from the stakhanovite worker to the devoted worker was portrayed as a logical continuation and manifestation of one's devotion to the regime. As a result, labor contribution and military participation were projected in the film as inseparable, forming a linear progression with the latter deriving directly from the former. It is worth mentioning that being released in 1950, *The Fall of Berlin* echoed major ideas of Stalin's speech of 1946. To be precise, Stalin argued that the soldiers' efforts alone were not sufficient to win the war, since it was necessary to possess resources like "...metals - for the production of armaments, equipment and industrial machinery; fuel - to ensure the operation of industry and transport; cotton - to manufacture army clothing; grain - to supply the army with food."³ The following rhetoric emphasized the underlying interdependence of industrial and military achievements, compressing the complexities of pre-war policies into a simplistic positive narrative. In this way, Chiaureli's work served as a cinematographic embodiment of Stalin's speech, reinforcing and propagating the cult of victory to a wide Soviet audience.

³ Stalin, Joseph. *Speeches Delivered at Meetings of Voters of the Stalin Electoral District*, (Moscow: Foreign Languages Publishing House, 1950), paragraph 31.

Although the film sought to embrace the unity of all Soviet republics, the way it was executed revealed the unofficial discrimination of non-Russian ethnicities during late Stalinism. Throughout the plot, the movie featured numerous non-Russian characters who contributed to the victorious outcome of the war. Nevertheless, these figures were systematically uninvolved in vital technical roles and strategic actions. This became distinctly apparent in the death of Yusuf, who was deliberately excluded by the director from raising the flag over the Reichstag (Figure 2).



Figure 2. Yusuf's death from *The Fall of Berlin. Part 2*

The following scene did not only oversimplify the complexity of the actual event but also functioned as an indication of systematic marginalization of non-Russians' military efforts. The fact that the film never specified Yusuf's ethnicity, presenting him as a generic Central Asian, underscores the depth of Russocentrism in recreating historical events. According to Boram Shin, Central Asian heroes were routinely ignored or not identified in propaganda narratives, lumping their experiences into a general notion of the Soviet wartime experience.⁴ In its essence, *The Fall of Berlin* was a cinematic variation of such narratives that intentionally denied the

⁴ Shin, Boram. "Red Army Propaganda for Uzbek Soldiers and Localised Soviet Internationalism during World War II" In *The Soviet and Post-Soviet Review* 42, (Leiden: Brill, 2015), 48.

recognition of servicemen outside titular nationality (Raqymjan Qoshqarbaev being a concrete example in this case). Profound invisibility of non-Russian soldiers was additionally exemplified by the way enemy forces refer to the Soviet army (Figure 3).



Figure 3. German officer updating Hitler from *The Fall of Berlin. Part 2*

Labeling multiethnic troops of the Red army as ‘Russians’ appeared as a repeating motive in the film, emphasizing the prevalence of Russocentric narratives in late Stalinist media. Via this generalization, the movie mirrored the nationality-based hierarchy of the Soviet army, in which the Russian soldiers were implicitly positioned as the ‘elder brothers’ that possessed authority over their counterparts from other republics⁵. In this manner, Chiaureli’s work failed to maintain an unrealistic image of ethnic unity while revealing the genuine segregation of minority nationalities.

Moreover, *The Fall of Berlin* carried profound Cold War propaganda, advancing the central strategic aims of the late Stalinist period. In terms of international geopolitics, the resolution of the Second World War did not mark peaceful times but rather a renewed chapter of

⁵ Carmack, Roberto J. “All to the front?: Nationality and Military Mobilization in Wartime Kazakhstan.” In *Kazakhstan in World War II: Mobilization and Ethnicity in the Soviet Empire*. (Lawrence: University Press of Kansas, 2019), 13.

the tensions between capitalism and communism. Speaking specifically, post-war reality was defined by growing ideological competition between the Soviet Union and Western states, which urged both sides to adjust their propaganda campaigns⁶. In the case of the USSR, by 1946 the West was largely perceived as a devious and omnipresent adversary or at best a rival, while the term ‘ally’ gained a sarcastic and derogatory meaning⁷. The increasing hostility gradually became embedded in the Soviet Cold War propaganda, which was also reflected in Chiaureli’s film. The following was especially evident in a negotiation of British and Nazi representatives against Soviet forces in Stalingrad (Figure 4).



Figure 4. Dialogue between Charles Bedston and Hermann Göring from *The Fall of Berlin. Part 1*

The lavish background surrounding Bedston and Göring functioned as a vital visual element, which highlighted the corruption of capitalists against the modesty of communists. In this manner, the aesthetic choices of the film were rendered as supplementary expressions of ideological conflict, aimed at portraying Western countries as a unified enemy of the socialists. The artistic decision to introduce specifically a British character to embody the hypocrisy of the

⁶ Pechatnov, Vladimir. “Exercise in Frustration: Soviet Foreign Propaganda in the Early Cold War, 1945-47” In *Cold War History*, (London: Frank Class, 2001), 4.

⁷ Pechatnov, Exercise in Frustration, 13.

Allied Powers can be contextualized through Stalin's response to Winston Churchill's Iron Curtain speech of 1946. In his interview to a *Pravda* correspondent, the Soviet leader stated that "...Mr. Churchill and his friends bear a striking resemblance to Hitler and his friends."⁸ Such comparison deepened the political antagonism between the powers, disregarding the wartime cooperation and former allianceship. Overall, the scene of British and German statesmen served as a rhetorical representation of the confrontation between Stalin and Churchill, explicitly underscoring the doctrinal rivalry of capitalism and socialism. At this point, the propagandistic value of Chiaureli's work transcended the temporal boundaries of the Second World War, promoting Stalinist Cold War rhetoric through visual metaphors.

⁸ Stalin, Joseph. *Interview to "Pravda" Correspondent Concerning Mr. Winston Churchill's Speech at Fulton*, (Moscow: Soviet News, 1947), paragraph 5.

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Filmography

The Fall of Berlin [Падение Берлина] (1929), dir. Mikheil Chiaureli